Lech Lecha 5786 (1)

פרשת לך לך. Hashem instructs Avram (12:1) לֶךְ לְךָ מֵאַרְצְךָ וּמִמּוֹלַדְתְּךָ וּמִבֵּית אָבִיךָ אֶל הָאָרֶץ אֲשֶׁר אַרְאֶךָּ - Cut off all of your previous connections, move someplace else and start a new life. A few פסוקים later it says (12:4) וַיֵּלֶךְ אַבְרָם כַּאֲשֶׁר דִּבֶּר אֵלָיו ה' וַיֵּלֶךְ אִתּוֹ לוֹט וְאַבְרָם בֶּן חָמֵשׁ שָׁנִים וְשִׁבְעִים שָׁנָה בְּצֵאתוֹ מֵחָרָן. This pasuk requires tremendous elucidation; it is far more complicated than it appears on the surface. The אזנים לתורה, the Lutzker Rav, R' Zalman Sorotzkin asks a series of penetrating and pointed questions which makes you think "How come I didn't think of that?" וַיֵּלֶךְ אַבְרָם כַּאֲשֶׁר דִּבֶּר אֵלָיו ה' - The first question he asks is what's the פסוק telling you? Is there any other reason that Avram would have gone? Why does the pasuk need to explicitly say כַּאֲשֶׁר דִּבֶּר אֵלָיו ה'? The second question is וַיֵּלֶךְ אִתּוֹ לוֹט - Lot went along with him. But didn't Hashem just say he should leave his whole family behind? הקדוש ברוך הוא commanded Avram in the first pasuk וּמִבֵּית אָבִיךָ. Lot is from בֵּית אָבִיךָ. How did Avram bring Lot along with him? He asks a third question: וְאַבְרָם בֶּן חָמֵשׁ שָׁנִים וְשִׁבְעִים שָׁנָה בְּצֵאתוֹ מֵחָרָן - the pasuk gives us his age. Why is the pasuk telling us his age now? What difference does that make? Also, if you would have left his age out, it would read like this: וַיֵּלֶךְ אַבְרָם כַּאֲשֶׁר דִּבֶּר אֵלָיו ה' וַיֵּלֶךְ אִתּוֹ לוֹט בְּצֵאתוֹ מֵחָרָן - This recitation of Avram's age breaks up the narrative of Avram's leaving. What purpose is served by giving us his age in the middle of this pasuk?

He answers that when Avram left in the following pasuk, he took along with him all of the people that he influenced - וְאֶת הַנֶּפֶשׁ אֲשֶׁר עָשׂוּ בְחָרָן. So we would say his nephew is a כל שכן and would certainly be included, and that's why Lot came along. However, the pasuk reveals to us in a subtle fashion Lot's ulterior motive. What was Avram's motive? To do the דבר השם, as the pasuk says כַּאֲשֶׁר דִּבֶּר אֵלָיו ה'. What was Lot's motive? וַיֵּלֶךְ אִתּוֹ לוֹט. There are two words in the Torah that in English both mean "with him": אִתּוֹ and עמו. In English, they mean the same thing, but אִתּוֹ means to go with him for your own purposes and עמו means כאיש אחד בלב אחד, with one motive, for exactly the same reason; עמו is a far greater connection than אִתּוֹ. Lot was going אִתּוֹ. It was a superficial connection and not the same thing as עמו. Therefore, he went for his own purposes and not for the מחשבה of Avram. What was Lot's purpose? Why did Lot want to come along with Avram? The answer is, וְאַבְרָם בֶּן חָמֵשׁ שָׁנִים וְשִׁבְעִים שָׁנָה בְּצֵאתוֹ מֵחָרָן. Avram is 75 years old. As we say in the lingo, he's no spring chicken, להבדיל. He's not a young man. Which fool would leave his uncle? Remember something, יצחק is not around yet. Right now, aside from Sarah, who is not a יורש, he is his closest living relative. He's Avram's יורש. Avram was a rich man. There's all the reason in the world to stick with him. If Avram is going someplace, he's taking his wealth with him, and therefore Lot was coming along. Lot's actual purpose was not because of his wanting to do what Avram does. It was a different כוונה completely, and that was to do what was good for him.

In ספר דברים we have the famous pasuk (28:9) וְהָלַכְתָּ בִּדְרָכָיו - we have to go in the ways of הקדוש ברוך הוא. We understand that we do everything that Hashem does because we cannot really understand Hashem, but we're following His ways. Hashem is a רחום, חנון, does חסד. This pasuk started from the beginning of our creation of כלל ישראל, of אברהם אבינו, the first of the אבות, tells you והלכת בדרכיו means literally, אברהם went in Hashem's way because that's what Hashem told him to do. A literal translation of the words that we've always learned for these years.

וְהָלַכְתָּ בִּדְרָכָיו means you follow in Hashem's ways because that is the רצון השם. We follow everything that Hashem tells us because we want to do רצון השם. If we can get up to that מדרגה, which אברהם אבינו was, and we can aspire to that greatness, we will not have ulterior motives.

We all do things for our own ulterior motives. We always identify with אברהם and look down at לוט, saying that he was self-seeking. Aren't we all like that to some degree? Let us work on ourselves to aspire to the level of אברהם אבינו and to be better people and to serve הקדוש ברוך הוא בלב שלם.

https://youtu.be/nDt5mDhLGkQ